



<< GYAN PRAKASH

LIBERTY, WITH DEATH

Two nations were born, torn from a dream of one. India and the world changed in ways never imagined.

The world changed in the 1940s. The decade opened with the aggressive imperial and racial ambitions of Germany and Japan engulfing the globe in a truly total conflict. World War II witnessed millions being herded into concentration camps, millions more being slaughtered on the battlefields, and densely populated cities being levelled by aerial bombardments. The atomic bombs dropped by the United States on Hiroshima and Nagasaki in August 1945 were a fitting symbol of the war's unspeakable violence. The nuclear explosions also marked the beginning of the Cold War and the end of the European world dominance. The Nazi genocide of the Jews and barbarism of the war had already robbed Europe of its claims as a superior civilisation.

The mobilisation of the colonies in the war effort in the name of freedom further undermined Europe's imperial dominance. The winds of change had begun blowing well before the beginning of the decade. The end of World War I witnessed the collapse of the Austro-Hapsburg and Ottoman empires, and the upsurge of nationalism in Eastern Europe and Asia. The Weimar Republic in Germany succumbed to Hitler, Mussolini triumphed in Italy, Japan militarised and acquired an empire, and Stalin embarked on breakneck industrialisation and ruthless political consolidation. It was the unraveling of the liberal imperial order and the onset of an era of mass society and politics.

Nationalism in India also took to mass mobilisation, dealing a death-blow to the liberal politics of constitutionalism. Mahatma Gandhi turned the Congress into a mass party, successfully inserting the illiterate peasantry into democratic politics. Backed by popular mobilisation, the

Congress pressed its claims to power. But so did Mohammed Ali Jinnah and B.R. Ambedkar on behalf of Muslims and Dalits, respectively. The Congress did spectacularly well in the 1937 elections, forming several provincial ministries, but the communal divisions were already quite visible.

When the British Viceroy Lord Linlithgow proclaimed on September 3, 1939, that India was at war with Germany, underlining India's colonial status, the turmoil surfaced. Pointing to Britain's hypocrisy of proclaiming it a war of freedom, while refusing to relinquish colonial control, the Congress ministries resigned. Jinnah welcomed the "deliverance" from "Hindu bondage" and the Muslim League passed a resolution in March 1940, demanding Pakistan. The die was cast.

The Quit India movement of 1942, launched with the August "uprising" in Bombay, signalled a mass challenge to the British rule. The imperial response was fierce. With Gandhi, Nehru and much of the Congress leadership jailed, the initiative was passed to the local leaders, students, and socialist activists. Much like 1857, the upheaval in the Gangetic belt took the form of a peasant rebellion. Student leaders and Kisan Sabha activists in Bihar and Uttar Pradesh attacked government properties, uprooted

railway lines, and paralysed the administration. Socialist leader Jayaprakash Narayan set up a "provisional Government". Gandhi, the apostle of non-violence, declared that violence was preferable to cowardice. India was in upheaval.

Battered by Germany in Europe and by Japan in Southeast Asia, the British feared the impact of Subhash Chandra Bose's radio broadcasts calling for rebellion. Their unlikely allies

The 1940s saw the British leaving the subcontinent and India becoming an independent nation.